

PRO-ACTIVE

- In December 2006, Gandhi arranged a dialogue between Mamata Banerjee and the chief minister over the Singur issue.
- In March, after seeing Nandigram images on TV, he rebuked the Government saying, "I cannot be so casual to the oath I have taken as to restrict my reaction to a pious expression of anguish and outrage."
- After the November 9-11 reclaiming of Nandigram, he strongly condemned Marxist action and asked Jyoti Basu to intervene.
- He visited Nandigram last week to assess the situation.



GOOD VIBES:
Gandhi (left)
with Buddhadeb

(he had earlier gone to the district hospital in Tamluk after the March 14 incident), a place where Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya is yet to set foot in, the people finally saw a saviour among the stream of politicians who have been there to gain political mileage. Touching his feet, hugging him, telling him exactly what has been going on (the CPI-M cadres still terrorise them and CRPF is not helping their cause), and hoping that he will help save their lives. The Governor played cricket with locals, and offered words of comfort, and came back to ask the state administration difficult questions. Gandhi, after November 9, has not only sought former chief minister Jyoti Basu's help in restoring harmony in the state, he is almost spearheading the peace process in West Bengal.

But in a democracy which places him in a titular capacity, can the 62-year-old Gandhi really make a difference? Bose, after Gandhi's visit to Nandigram, taunted, "We saw him playing cricket with the local boys on television. Pity, he was bowled in the first ball itself." Bose has been critical of the Governor, contending that he had overstepped his constitutional definition.

Though experts agree that it is within a governor's discretion to warn, advise and encourage the state, the state administration holds enough power to have him removed. The articulate Gandhi, for his part, has certain ideas on the role of the governor. In a

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GOPALKRISHNA GANDHI, WEST BENGAL GOVERNOR

column in 2005, he wrote, "The Constitution positions the governor in the engine car, but not in the engine-driver's seat. It places them a little behind and above the driver, at a point of slight elevation, from where the driver's skills, reflexes and direction can be overseen, from where the governor can also see the track ahead and render timely warnings, encouragement and sometimes, blow the whistle, without any backseat driving!"

Thus, his timely warnings and his whistle blowing, though irksome for the state Government, cannot be ignored. Gandhi is known for taking tough stands on things that he feels strongly about. As the Indian High Commissioner in South Africa and Sri Lanka, the literature graduate from St Stephen's College, Delhi is used to dealing with conflict-ridden areas and their administrators. He wrote a book on the plight of the Tamil tea labourers in Sri Lanka, along with a play called *Dara Shukoh*. He has also translated Vikram Seth's *A Suitable Boy* in Hindi. Having served as the secretary to the President of India between 1997 and 2000, the former IAS officer's grasp of politics is more than that of many state leaders he deals with now.

As he plays a proactive role in trying to restore peace in Nandigram and

West Bengal, no one can be under the illusion that a governor's role in a state is of no consequence. That Gandhi's opinion is important to everyone is evident by the way every political party is wooing him right now. Bhattacharya made it clear that the question of asking the Governor to be removed doesn't arise, adding his own personal touch. "He is a nice man...I have good relations with him. We not only discuss politics but also literature. We exchange books also," he said. A few days ago, a local Congress leader, believing that since Gandhi was criticising the Marxists, he would be favouring other parties, tried to get close to him. Only to be politely asked to speak to him later, in more formal circumstances. The Trinamool leadership went to meet him a few days ago and found him "a little aloof". It is clear that Gopal Krishna Gandhi doesn't favour anyone.

Except the people of his state. In 1946, the last British governor of Bengal, Frederick Burrows, had asked Mahatma Gandhi about his role. "What would you like me to do?" Gandhi replied, "Nothing. Your Excellency." That kind of defined the governor's constitutional role in India. But Gandhi is definitely not following his grandfather's advice. ■